

Shadow to Steel

Obedience, Iron, and the Return of the King

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The King does not return the same as
when he left. He returns forged in the
fire of obedience.

*To those walking through the valley and the forge,
may you walk the path that leads to steel.*

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Introduction

Following years of decline, on July 5, 2022 I was diagnosed with Relapsing Polychondritis — a rare, chronic, and often fatal autoimmune disease that attacks and destroys the body’s cartilage, particularly in the eyes, ears, nose, respiratory system, and trachea.

In my case, the disease had ravaged nearly every system. It destroyed my right knee (requiring surgery), my left hip (requiring replacement), and my nasal cartilage (rebuilt from chest cartilage, which revealed almost none left in the ribs). Looking back now, that outcome was merciful compared to the total destruction and floating chest many others endure.

In the recliner, facing what looked like my certain end, a great fear fell over me: I was going to die. After a few minutes, I thought to myself, “This changes nothing. I was born, and like every person born into this world, I am going to die.” The only difference now was that I had an idea of the timing — imminent — and the means: destruction of my cartilage and airways.

Then I prayed to the Lord. First, I confessed my sins against Him. Second, I apologized for my arrogance in believing all I had accomplished was due to me alone, instead of recognizing those things as blessings from the Lord. Finally, I said, “If it is my time, then it is my time. If it is not my time, tell me what to do to fix myself, and I’ll do it.”

The next morning, in the twilight between sleep and waking, the Lord answered: “Bench. Squat. Deadlift.”

For those unfamiliar with powerlifting or gym culture, these are known as the Big Three — multi-joint compound lifts. A counter-intuitive recommendation for a patient with a serious connective tissue disease.

That answer was not a miracle. It was a path. A forge. A way through the valley of the shadow of death.

Years later, a friend asked about that moment. His question was simple: “Did you make a bargain with the Lord, or did you make a vow?” I replied, “One does not bargain with the Lord. I made a vow.” He pointed me to Ecclesiastes 5:4–7 and Deuteronomy 23:21–23:

Deuteronomy 23:21

If you make a vow to the Lord do not be lax in paying it off, for the Lord your God will certainly require it of you and you would be guilty of sin.

This book is the story of that path — from near-death weakness to restoration, from betrayal to sovereignty, from Shadow to Steel.

Chapter 1

The Black Marble Room

Five years before the recliner, before the diagnosis, before the voice, I was already in the Valley of the Shadow of Death. I just didn't know the name for it yet.

Nothing was going right.

- I had been wrongfully terminated from my job, my restricted stock awards, spitefully canceled. I lost a significant amount of wealth.
- Shortly afterward, lightning struck our home. The top floor burned. The lower floor flooded from the firefighting efforts. Most of the house was destroyed.
- Having lost my job, the person that had driven the termination was using the full legal weight of the bank which I had worked to blacklist me, I began an independent consultancy which required me to be away from home five to six days a week,
- My family relationships began to fray under the strain.

Living alone in cheap hotel rooms sinking with neither an end nor aid in sight the weight of it all became unbearable. One night, I cried out to the Lord with raw desperation: "Lord, I cannot bear this any longer. If there is an end to it, please let me know. If not, at least tell me that too, so I can resign myself to this trap."

That night I had the most vivid dream of my life.

I stood in a vast, windowless chamber carved from a single block of polished black marble. The walls and floor were seamless, cold, reflective - like night itself made solid. There was no door, no window, no visible exit. Far above, impossibly high in the ceiling, a tiny opening let in a faint shaft of light. It might as well have been on the moon.

I tried to climb. I wedged my body into the smooth corners, straining upward, but the marble offered no grip. Even if I gained height, exhaustion would have pulled me back down to my death.

Defeated and breathing hard, a simple marble bench appeared behind me. I sat down and told myself, "Don't panic. You're a smart person. You can figure this out."

Then I felt a presence to my left — masculine, calm, and authoritative — yet I could never see Him directly. He remained just beyond the edge of my vision, always slightly out of sight. In a quiet, steady voice He said, "We have decided to show you what is going to happen to you."

He led me to the left-most corner of the room — the very corner I had already examined and found nothing. Now there was a doorway. Behind it stretched a long hallway lined with identical black marble doors on both sides. We walked until He stopped at one and said, “This is your door.”

I opened it and stepped into a smaller black marble room, identical to the first. In the center, on a raised pedestal, sat a golden tabernacle — exactly like the one that holds the Eucharist in church. I opened the doors and looked inside.

I cannot describe what I saw. I can only tell you the single overwhelming thought that flooded me: That’s not so bad.

I stepped back into the hallway. The presence was still there. We walked to the far end and exited. I was back in the original large chamber. The marble bench remained, but the doorway and hallway had vanished. Only the tiny unreachable light high above remained.

I sat down again, still trying to solve the puzzle, and then I woke up.

I never forgot that dream. It was the first quiet answer to a prayer I had not yet fully prayed. Seven years later, when I sat in the recliner facing what looked like certain death, the Lord had already shown me the truth: even in the most sealed, lightless chamber, a way out existed — if I was willing to wait, to listen, and to obey.

The dream was the seed planted in darkness. The prayer — “tell me what to do and I will do it” — became the vow.

And the iron would become the path.

I would come to realize, that I was walking through the valley of the shadow of death. But, before that realization came to me another was to precede. The same friend that had asked if I have made a bargain with or a vow to the Lord had also likened my circumstance to that of Job.

The Book of Job is one of the oldest and most profound books in the Bible. It is not primarily about why “bad things happen to good people.” It is about **faith under extreme testing** - whether a man will serve God for who God is, or only for the blessings he receives. The story opens in Heaven with a dialog between God and Satan. God points out Job as “blameless and upright, a man who fears God and shuns evil.” Satan immediately accuses Job of conditional faith: “Does Job fear God for nothing?” That is to say, Satan claims Job only serves God because God has built a protective hedge of blessing around Job.

God then permits Satan to test Job - but with strict limits. Satan cannot kill Job or take his life. Everything else is on the table. The story illustrates that Satan does not attack randomly. Rather, Satan uses a systematic, multi-layered strategy designed to break Job’s faith from every direction. And rest assured Satan will use the same strategy with each and every person. Satan’s attack vectors as outlined in chapters one through two are outlined below:

1. Economic - Livelihood Destruction (Job 1:14-17)

- Sabeans steal oxen and donkeys and kill servants.

- Fire from heaven burns the sheep and shepherds.
- Chaldeans steal camels and kill more servants.

Satan wipes out Job's entire wealth and business in one day. The goal: remove security and provision.

2. Family - Emotional Devastation (Job 1:18-19)

- A great wind collapses the house where all ten of Job's children are feasting and kills everyone of them.

Satan removes Job's entire legacy and support system in a single moment. The goal: crush the heart.

3. Physical - Bodily Affliction (Job 2:7-8)

- Satan strikes Job with painful sores from the soles of his feet to the top of his head.

Job is left scraping himself with broken pottery while sitting in ashes. The goal: constant, unrelenting torment that makes every moment miserable

4. Relations - Social Isolation (Job 2:9-10 and throughout)

- Job's wife tells him to "Curse God and die."
- Job's three friends (and later Elihu) arrive, but instead of comfort they accuse Job of hidden sin and judge him relentlessly for 30+ chapters.

Satan turns the people closest to Job into sources of pain and accusation. The goal: total loneliness.

5. Spiritual - Psychological Attack (the entire of the book)

- Job is plunged into deep despair, questioning why he was ever born, feeling abandoned by God, and wrestling with the apparent injustice of it all.

Satan attacks the mind and the spirit, trying to drive Job to curse God. The goal: break the relationship with God

I had no understanding at the time that I was living through the very same multi-layered attack Satan had used against Job. In my ignorance, I simply fought harder to keep my head above water. The more I struggled, the deeper I sank into a darkness I could not name or escape. I was already walking through the valley of the shadow of death.

What I did not yet realize was that the Valley was also the forge.

Chapter 2

The Valley – The Place of Shadow and Fear

Psalm 22 - Suffering and Triumph of the Messiah

2 My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?
Why have you paid no heed to my cry for help,
to my cries of anguish?
3 O my God, I cry by day, but you do not answer,
by night, but I am afforded no relief.

Psalm 22 was written by King David around 1000–970 BC during one of his darkest periods. Most scholars believe it was composed while he was on the run during the rebellion of his own son Absalom. At the time, David was hunted, betrayed by his closest advisor, publicly humiliated, and utterly alone — living in the valley of the shadow of death.

I knew exactly how he felt.

For years the misfortune had been grinding me down. I felt a complete emotional disconnect from the woman I loved. The marriage that once anchored me had gone cold and silent. I prayed the same desperate question David did: My God, why have you abandoned me? At first I convinced myself the Lord had left because I was unworthy—I hadn't been to church in years. Then I began to wonder if God existed at all. Neither thought brought comfort.

Standing alone on the train platform into town, the sky darkened by heavy clouds. It was cold and damp, and a stinging bitter wind whipped across my face. At that moment I had an epiphany: this is exactly how my inner world felt. Yet I continued to pray. I still believed in God. I still sought comfort from the Lord. The devastating truth was not that God did not exist, but that I could no longer feel His presence. And I had no idea that I would have to walk through the valley of the shadow of death before I would feel it again.

The Summer of 2021, I was walking through the valley- I didn't fully recognize it. June. Middle of the season, yet I wore a hoodie outdoors because I was freezing down to my core. My right knee had been painful and swollen for six months due to a torn meniscus. - how it happened was beyond me. After repeated cortisone injections, insurance finally approved surgery. During the follow-up the surgeon told me he had sent fluid from my knee for cancer testing—it looked that abnormal. The result came back negative. Only

later visit would he realize the fluid was classic for the autoimmune disease that was already destroying me.

Physical therapy after knee surgery brought new pain in my left hip. Within weeks I could barely walk. The hip surgeon showed me comparative X-rays: the cartilage in my left hip had been completely erased while the right hip remained unchanged. "What could do something like that?" I asked. He had no answer.

Then came the dry cough and shortness of breath—constant, unnatural. Interns and nurses noticed it. The hip replacement itself triggered a major flare. Nasal cartilage was destroyed, leaving me with a saddle-nose deformity. The shortness of breath and chest pain continued. I bought a Peloton, mostly to help build leg strength following the two surgeries and I believe the shortness of breath convinced me it was due to poor conditioning - little did I know that the kind of shortness of breath I was experiencing was a classic autoimmune symptom. Every ride became a battle: coughing, gasping, fighting an invisible enemy that was killing me slowly, methodically, day by day.

January 2022, late one night I was lying in bed facing the truth: a silent killer was winning. I turned to the Lord with a simple, stripped-down prayer: "Lord, something is killing me. All I want is to know - what it is. Please get me in front of someone who can tell me before I die."

The next morning, in that quiet twilight between sleep and waking, a voice—not my own—spoke with calm authority:

"Don't worry about work, don't worry about insurance, just call everyone you can and take whatever appointment is available—today, tomorrow, a month, a year from now - It doesn't matter."

I started with the obvious: my ruined nose. I called ENT offices until, on the fifth try, a cheerful woman at Rush University answered. "You're in luck—we just reopened this week." She booked me with the department's top specialist, Dr. Papagiannopoulos.

A week later, I was sitting in the exam room waiting for the doctor. Once he arrived and we traded pleasantries, I went over the litany of maladies that had befallen me, each in its proper order. I dropped the surgical mask they had given me to wear at admittance showing him the saddle nose deformity and said - "then this happened." He replied, "I am sorry that happened to you." This was the first time anyone had expressed sympathy for the deformity that had befallen me. After which, he immediately referred me to rheumatology.

That same day, I met Dr. Block. He entered the exam room, looked me over and asked who referred me. I replied, Dr. Papagiannopoulos, he nodded in approval. I had managed to find the right doctor, one that could see the seriousness of my situation, and who would in turn refer me rightly to another that would help me - my prayer had been answered.

Dr. Block agreed, we needed to repair my nose. A biopsy was needed to aid in the identification of the disease. Over the course of the next six months, while waiting for my nasal reconstruction, I returned to Rush on a monthly basis for routine examinations and blood draws. During this time I met Doctor Revenaugh the surgeon that would repair my nose. Initially, he indicated that he would repair the saddle deformity but not the hole in the septum. I explained to him, I realized the septum repair had at best an 80

percent success rate but even in the case of a failure it is an improvement. I asked him to try, if it does not fully succeed that is fine at least we tried. He agreed to try.

The surgery went forward, I splints in my nose to protect the repair work to my septum, they would remain for the summer. The chest cartilage recovered to repair the saddle deformity was, as Dr. Revenaugh put it - 'barely viable'. The disease had destroyed my chest cartilage. Fortunately, it had remodeled itself into a fibrous tissue, something they had never seen before; I had been spared the fate of a 'loose chest', which is common in these instances.

On my next visit in July they delivered the diagnosis Relapsing Polychondritis; until the surgery the disease had been running at a constant low level - insidious - making it unidentifiable. It had impacted the cartilage in my right knee, destroyed the cartilage in my nose, chest, left hip, and was now slowly destroying the cartilage in my respiratory tract and trachea.

My childhood asthma returned and breathing became increasingly difficult. Doctor Block referred me for a pulmonary test. At the follow up, I met doctor Vashi, she began treating me for both my resurgent asthma as well as the damage done to my respiratory tract.

The diagnosis landed like a sentence: Relapsing Polychondritis. I now knew the name of the silent killer that had been destroying me piece by piece. My earlier prayer had been answered. In the recliner that July evening, the weight of it settled fully. I was going to die.

After a few minutes the fear gave way to clarity. I had already walked through the valley. I had already seen the black marble room. I had already heard the first quiet answer. In that moment I prayed as David once did in Psalm 22:

Psalm 22 - Suffering and Triumph of the Messiah

20 But you, O Lord, do not remain aloof from me;
O my Strength, come quickly to my aid.

I confessed my sins against the Lord. I apologized for the arrogance of believing everything I had accomplished was by my own strength instead of recognizing those things as blessings from Him. Then I made no bargain — only a vow.

“If it is my time, then it is my time. If it is not my time, tell me what to do to fix myself, and I will do it.”

The next morning, in the twilight between sleep and waking, the voice returned — calm and unmistakable:

“Bench. Squat. Deadlift.”

For those unfamiliar with powerlifting, these are the Big Three—the foundational compound lifts. For a man whose cartilage was being systematically destroyed by disease, the prescription sounded absurd. Yet, in that moment, I understood: this was not a miracle. This was a path. This was the forge - the forge I knew so well from childhood.

The valley showed me the darkness. The Lord had shown me the way out. Now the iron would become the fire that would refine - refine the shadow of death into steel.

Psalm 23 - Prayer to the Good Shepherd

4 Even though I wander through the valley of the shadow of death,

5 I will fear no evil, for you are at my side,

With your rod and your staff that comfort me.

The Lord heard my cries and answered - not with a miracle but a prescription. I was to step from the valley of the shadow of death into the forge that refines, and I knew the Lord was with me.

Chapter 3

The Forge – The Fire That Refines

I have known the fire of the forge longer than I realized. As a child, I suffered from severe asthma. Each day was the same: some days were manageable, others a struggle. But the nights were different. I would wake in the late hours gasping for air, chest tight, lungs constricted. My mother would come to my aid. Some nights I would pass out from lack of oxygen. Other nights I would collapse from exhaustion simply trying to breathe.

I never complained. I just kept going.

Years later, my Uncle Mike — who suffers from COPD — reflected on those days after Sunday brunch. He looked at me and said, “My sister once told me, you never complained about your asthma. You just kept going.”

He was right. Even then, without knowing the name for it, I was already walking through the first forge. The same enemy who would later attack my cartilage, my marriage, and my peace was already testing me in the quiet hours of childhood. He could not break me then, and he would not break me later.

I would often pray to the Lord, why this affliction, why me? Always, to no answer, not because the Lord did not hear my prayer but because the prayer itself was not correct - rather than asking the Lord for assistance I questioned Him. I resolved myself to overcome my affliction, I began running; working myself up to a 6-1/2 minute mile. I participated in mini-marathons, training marathon distance, weight training. Overtime, through fortitude and determination I got stronger. I convinced myself that the Lord was an observer and not a participant in my life. I drifted from the Church and came to despise any weakness in myself - weakness was something to remedied at all costs.

I now realize the purpose of the first forge was to develop a determination and will enabling to withstand the fire of the second forge. I returned to Church, prayed my Rosary daily and slowly I started to understand -

Malachi 3:2-3

2 But who will be able to endure the day of his coming,
and how can stand when he appears?

For he is like a refiner's fire
or fuller's soap.

He will sit refining and purifying:
he will purify the descendants of Levi
and refine them like gold and silver.
so that they may in righteousness
offer due sacrifice to the Lord.

The adversity we face has a purpose.

[Isaiah 48:10, Malachi 3:2-3, etc.]

Chapter 4

The Valley as Forge – The Same Fire

[Psalm 23:4]

Chapter 5

The Locusts and the Repayment

[Joel 2:25]

Chapter 6

Betrayal in the Valley

[Psalm 41:9]

Chapter 7

The Self-Built Prison

[Proverbs 14:1, 2 Timothy 3:1–5]

Chapter 8

Walking Through Without Bitterness

[Job's perseverance, Ephesians 4:31–32]

Chapter 9

The Three Pillars of Restoration

Chapter 10

The Final Vindication – Repaid Double

[Job 42:10–17]

Conclusion

Revelation 21:5 – “Behold, I make all things new.”

The locusts came. I cried out. God answered. The repayment is unfolding — one rep, one breath, one day at a time.